Dvar Torah: Parshas Tzav - Shabbos HaGadol

Mesorah, Time, and Standing Our Ground

A Child's Question

Here we are moving into another Shabbos, and it's particularly exciting because not only is it Parshas Tzav, it's also Shabbos HaGadol. A couple of weeks ago, my daughter asked me a question before I went to learn with my rebbi, Rav Chanan. She has a habit of doing this, asking questions for me to bring to him. Sometimes it's even a little bedtime incentive: if you go to bed, I'll ask Rav Chanan your question.

Her question was beautiful, directly connected to Pesach, but really much more impactful throughout the year and with all the chagim. She asked: Why is it that here in Eretz Yisrael, where we gratefully live, we have one Seder, while in Chutz LaAretz they have two? Without going into all the different halachos of someone from Chutz LaAretz coming here and the various minhagim they may follow, why this difference?

So I asked this to Rav Chanan. We went through some of the more basic halachos, the background of how Rosh Chodesh was originally established, the time needed to get messages out to different areas globally, and when you're dealing with a chag that begins on the fifteenth, maybe it's the fifteenth, maybe the sixteenth, that one-day shift creates the two-day observance.

But then he gave his own pshat, his own deeper answer. He said: We don't want to lose the mesorah. And that is such a beautiful, wonderful answer.

Masters of Time

When we look at the realities of one and two days of chag, one and two sedarim, we're reminded that we have a mesorah. Today we have a fixed calendar, a schedule we follow. But once upon a time, we had the Beis HaMikdash. And in the Beis HaMikdash, it was part of the avodah of Klal Yisrael, going back to one of the first mitzvos after Yetzias Mitzrayim, to declare the zmanim of the moon, to establish when the new month began.

We say this within our tefillos on the chagim: that Hashem chose us from all nations, and also that we're supposed to be masters over time. "מְקַדֵּשׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל וְהַזְּמַנִּים" (from the Yom Tov Shemoneh Esrei), He sanctifies Israel and the appointed times. We are supposed to be masters of time itself.

Rav Chanan's answer was that we don't want to lose the mesorah of how we did that and what the impact of it was in this world. In other words, we need to be reminded of what we used to do and put that into practice today, so that when we have the Beis HaMikdash Hashlishi and we start to have access, physical access, to all these additional mitzvos, we don't lose or forget how to do them.

The Great Shabbos

By Shabbos HaGadol, we have a custom brought down in the halacha sefarim. The Shulchan Aruch says that we have Shabbos HaGadol, and we call it that because of the great miracle which happened at that time. "שַׁבָּת שֶׁלִּפְנֵי הַפֶּסַח קוֹרִין אוֹתוֹ שַׁבָּת הַגָּדוֹל מִפְּנֵי הַנֵּס שֶׁנַּעֲשָׂה בּוֹ" (Shulchan Aruch, Orach Chaim 430:1), the Shabbos before Pesach is called Shabbos HaGadol because of the miracle that occurred on it.

The Rema adds that we are accustomed to read from the Haggadah, from "Avadim Hayinu" until "Lechaper al kol avonoseinu," until we speak about doing teshuvah on all of our aveiros. And then there's a larger debate about what exactly was the nes, what was the miracle.

But regardless of the specific details, the fact that all these years later, even before the Seder, we get to debate, we get to remember: What was it that was so unique and special about that Shabbos? And to go back into the Haggadah itself, to remind ourselves that we were slaves, that we will be doing teshuvah, ties into so much of what we learn when we go through the various parshiyos on korbanos.

Tzav: The Command That Requires Extra Push

Parshas Tzav starts off based exactly on this concept. Because what are we doing? We are learning, we are reiterating, we are reminding ourselves of what was already said and done previously. We're going back into the idea of a korban that's completely burnt on the mizbei'ach, the altar.

And for this reason as well, we call this parsha "Tzav," command. Rashi explains: "אֵין צַו אֶלָּא לְשׁוֹן זֵרוּז" (Rashi on Vayikra 6:2), tzav is a language of urging, of extra encouragement. There needs to be an extra koach, an extra reminder, an extra push, to do the right thing when we don't necessarily see the intrinsic value, and sometimes when we see that there might be a loss from this.

When we look at life, when we look at mitzvos, when we look at Torah, so much of what we do, if we don't have our mesorah, if we don't remind ourselves where we're coming from, a lot of it can seem like a waste. A lot of it seems hard to do, because I'm giving up something. By the korban that we're talking about within Tzav, this is a korban olah, where the entire thing is

burned up completely. That's my hard work going into purchasing this korban. And then what's going to happen to it? It's going to go up entirely to Hashem.

And you might think: Does Hashem enjoy something being burnt entirely until there's nothing left and calls it a "רֵיחַ נִיחוֹחַ לַה'" (Vayikra 1:9), a pleasing aroma to Hashem? Truthfully, Hashem does. Hashem tells us to do something and He loves it. But sometimes it's harder for us to follow through with it.

Avodah Today: Davening in Place of Korbanos

When we look at it as a concept of avodah, as a tafkid, as a job, very truthfully it is hard to do every day. We say that avodah today is tefillah. "וּנְשַׁלְּמָה פָרִים שְׂפָתֵינוּ" (Hoshea 14:3), we will pay with the offerings of our lips. We say, based upon the teachings from the Rambam and other sefarim, that when we learn through the korbanos, when we read out the korbanos (which is the reason why we have the korban sections at the beginning of Shacharis, and many people are noheg by Mincha as well to read through them), it says that we are yotzei by those korbanos. When we are davening, we are doing that bimkom, in place of them.

Shacharis is in place of the korban tamid of the morning. Mincha is in place of the korban tamid of the afternoon. The fact is that I'm still giving up something. I'm giving up my time, my focus, my energy. My money is in that time that I'm dedicating. I could be working, I could be working out, I could be listening to music, sleeping in. All these different things I could be doing. And why do we do it?

We could say it from two sides. One side is because it's as if I'm bringing the korban today. The other side is: I don't want to lose the mesorah of where I'm coming from. We are people of avodah, people of service.

Not Everyone Does Everything

Not everybody can be doing all the services. We have 613 mitzvos, and many of them don't apply to us in practice. If we had the Beis HaMikdash, I'm not a Kohen. I can't sprinkle blood on the mizbei'ach. I'm not a Levi. There are even mitzvos connected to situations we never want to be in. So we are yotzei by learning them. We are maintaining the mesorah of the avodah. We are staying connected to Hashem in this way.

Pigul and Notar: The Importance of Proper Time

Very beautifully as well, we have a reminder in this week's parsha about pigul, things which become invalid through improper intention, and notar, things which are left over. There is a time and a place to bring a korban. If it is left beyond that time, if your thoughts are not aligned within the moment, then it becomes invalid. Also, in these cases, it becomes assur, forbidden. There's no hana'ah from it. You have to burn it and dispose of it.

Why? Because just like my tefillah Shacharis is connected to the Tamid boker, the morning offering, just like Shabbos HaGadol is reminding us of the nes which happened, the nes itself that we are reminded of is that we brought the sheep in and we told the Mitzrim exactly what we were doing. When they asked, "What are you doing? Why are you tying up the sheep?" (something that they worshipped as a deity, tied to the bed), we answered: "Oh, we're going to shecht this on Shabbos."

What? That was a nes, that the Mitzrim didn't respond, didn't do anything at all against the Jews. In the same way, we also have reminders of what happens when we do things at the wrong time. You can do the right action at the wrong time, and things can go bad. I was supposed to cook my Shabbos dinner on the fire with delicious food, and if I try to do it on Shabbos instead of the day before, it comes out completely different. There's a reminder of these realities, that timing matters.

Standing Our Ground

Most importantly, we also look back and tie this to the nes of Shabbos HaGadol. That the Jews, the Yidden, stood their ground. They told the Mitzrim exactly what they were going to do. And even though the Mitzrim were mortified of this concept, because it wasn't something they could relate to, to them what we were doing was an abomination in their eyes, we didn't flinch.

We didn't say in a meek way, "Oh, I'm so sorry that I'm about to do this, please don't hurt me." No. We had a commandment. Hashem told us what to do, and we did it.

Shabbos HaGadol, the great Shabbos, the nes, is also the fact that we did what we were supposed to do to begin with. And nothing bad, only good, happened to us from that. From there, we were zocheh, we merited. We had Yetzias Mitzrayim. We had the first Pesach. We were able to bring the Korban Pesach.

My friend reminds me periodically that I will have to break my vegetarianism for the Korban Pesach, and I will, with simcha, partake in that korban at that time. That is what we should look forward to.

Doing the Right Thing

When we do the right thing, we put one foot in front of the other in the way of Hashem. And as Rav Chanan said in his answer to my daughter, when she asked why we have two sedarim in Chutz LaAretz and one here, why we have two days Yom Tov there and one day here in Eretz Yisrael, it is because we have the mesorah of what is right. We have the mesorah of what we are supposed to be doing for the Beis HaMikdash. And we don't want to lose that connection.

By doing the correct actions today, in the way that we can, through limud Torah, through tefillah, through maaseh mitzvos, through performing the commandments, we are zocheh in the mitzvos. We are yotzei. It is as if we are fulfilling them. But we are also preparing ourselves for when we will actually do them physically.

Questions for Your Shabbos Table

As we enter Shabbos HaGadol and prepare for Pesach, consider these reflections:

On Mesorah:
- What practices do I maintain even when I don't fully understand them, simply because they connect me to my heritage?
- How can I better appreciate the gift of our transmitted tradition?

On Time and Alignment:
- Where in my life am I doing the right thing at the wrong time?
- How can I better align my actions with their proper moments?

On Standing Our Ground:
- When have I hesitated to do what I knew was right because of what others might think?
- How can I develop the courage to act with clarity when Hashem's will is clear?

On Avodah:
- Do I see my davening as a burden or as maintaining the precious mesorah of service?
- What would change if I truly viewed my tefillah as bringing a korban?

Closing: Preparing for the Pesach to Come

We hold onto the mesorah. We daven. We learn. We act. Even when it is difficult. Even when we do not see immediate results. Because we are preparing ourselves.

As Rav Chanan said, we do not want to lose the mesorah. We don't want to forget how to establish time, how to bring korbanos, how to serve Hashem in the Beis HaMikdash. So we practice now, in the ways available to us.

May it be a bracha for all of us that the reading of the sections of the Haggadah that we do today, on Shabbos HaGadol, should be a reminder for the Korban Pesach that we will bring, not just in memory, but in reality, in just a few more days.

May we merit to stand with the same clarity and courage that our ancestors showed on that first Shabbos HaGadol, doing what Hashem commands without hesitation, without apology, with full confidence that when we align ourselves with His will at the right time, only good can come from it.

And may we soon merit to see the Beis HaMikdash rebuilt, to establish the months through witnesses and the Sanhedrin, to bring actual korbanos on the mizbei'ach, and to fulfill all the mitzvos that we currently practice only in learning and in memory.

A wonderful, beautiful Shabbos to everyone. Gut Shabbos and a kosher and freilichen Pesach.

Gut Shabbos!